



RESTORATIONESSENTIALS

Factory-Correct Restoration Reference

1987 Buick Grand National Restoration Guide

Model Year 1987

Model	Buick Regal Grand National (WE2) / GNX
Platform	GM G-body, rear-wheel drive
Engine	3.8L LC2 SFI intercooled turbo V6 (245 hp)
Transmission	200-4R automatic overdrive, 3.42 axle
Notable	Final year; 20,193 GN + 547 GNX built

Every specification in this guide was checked against factory literature, marque references, period road tests, and documented survivor cars. Where sources disagree or the record is silent, this guide says so rather than guessing.

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Chapter 1 — Buick and the Turbo Regal Idea

Buick spent the late 1970s turbocharging its V6 while the rest of Detroit downsized and apologized. The engineers who had built the GS 455 asked what boost could do for the 231 V6, and the answer ran from the 1978 Regal Sport Coupe through NASCAR manufacturer's titles in 1981 and 1982 to the Grand National package itself. By 1987 the formula was finished: an intercooled, sequentially injected turbo V6 in an all-black Regal coupe that outran every V8 GM sold that year. This guide covers the 1987 car — the last, fastest, and most produced of the line — and the 547 GNXs built beside it.

Chapter 2 — What Makes 1987 Different

- **Power:** 245 hp and 355 lb-ft, up 10 hp and 25 lb-ft on 1986. Period tests put the car at 0–60 in about 6.1 seconds and the quarter in the high 13s.
- **Volume:** 20,193 Grand Nationals — Buick extended GN-only production past the planned July Regal shutdown through December 1987, and roughly 10,000 cars were built after that August decision with a fixed package of 17 required options.
- **Final form:** 1987 is the last year of the rear-drive G-body Regal. The GNX exists only this year.
- **Siblings:** the WE4 Turbo T (1,547 built) put the same powertrain in a lighter car — aluminum bumper supports and wheels — available in colors. Know it before you judge a 'black GN with gray bumpers.'



Chapter 3 — VIN and SPID-Label Decoding

The 17-character VIN reads like the worked example **1G4GJ117XHP400001**: **1** United States, **G** General Motors, **4** Buick, **G** the G-body series, **J** the Regal trim level (the K code planned for the Grand National was never used), **1** two-door coupe, restraint code, engine digit **7** for the LC2 3.8 SFI intercooled turbo, check digit, **H** for 1987, **P** for the Pontiac, Michigan plant, and the serial from 400001.

The VIN alone proves a turbo Regal coupe — not a Grand National. The Grand National is option code **WE2**, and it is proven on the SPID (Service Parts Identification) label under the trunk lid, which must carry a VIN matching the dash plate. A WE2-code SPID plus the LC2 engine digit is the identity. Everything else — black paint, badges, interior — can be and has been added to ordinary turbo Regals, which is why the SPID label is the first thing a buyer photographs and the last thing a restorer 'restores' away.

Chapter 4 — The LC2: Intercooled Turbo 3.8

The LC2 is a 3.8-liter (231 cu in) 90-degree V6 with sequential fuel injection and an intercooled Garrett turbocharger: cast-iron block and heads, 8.0:1 compression, 3.80 × 3.40-inch bore and stroke, four main bearings, hydraulic lifters. Officially 245 horsepower at 4,400 rpm and 355 lb-ft at 2,000 rpm — the torque figure, arriving that low, is the car's whole personality. Restoration doctrine for the LC2 is documentation-first: the intercooler, its ducting, and the turbo plumbing are the parts most often swapped, upgraded, or lost, and the factory configuration is the value. Engine-management is chip-based; period-correct calibration is part of the car's originality story, and performance chips belong in the car's file with their paperwork, not silently in the ECM.

Chapter 5 — The GNX in Depth

Buick sent 547 Grand Nationals to ASC/McLaren for the GNX — 'Grand National Experimental' — at a \$10,995 premium (\$29,900 total). The work was mechanical, not cosmetic: a Garrett turbocharger with a ceramic impeller, a larger intercooler, low-restriction exhaust, a reprogrammed ECM, transmission upgrades, a ladder-bar and Panhard-rod rear suspension revision with added frame bracing, functional front-fender heat vents, flared arches, 16-inch black mesh wheels, deleted exterior emblems, Stewart-Warner gauges, and a serialized dash plaque numbered within the 547. Official rating: 276 hp and 360 lb-ft, numbers the entire hobby understands to be conservative — this guide prints the official figures and notes the period dyno reputation without adopting a bigger number it cannot document.

For restorers the GNX lesson is identity discipline squared: 547 cars, every one documented, and a tribute industry behind them. The serialized plaque, the ASC conversion hardware, and the paper file are the car. Nothing about a GNX should be 'improved' casually — each change is a withdrawal from a documented account.

Chapter 6 — Transmission: The 200-4R and the 3.42 Axle

One transmission was offered: the 200-4R four-speed automatic overdrive, behind a 3.42 rear axle (G80 limited-slip was part of the late-run required package and common throughout). The GNX received its own transmission calibration work at ASC/McLaren. Restoration sequence: record the transmission's identification before removal, and treat shift calibration as originality — the way these cars shift is part of how they were reviewed and remembered.



Chapter 7 — Suspension, Brakes, Steering, and Wheels

The Grand National package carried the Gran Touring suspension and fast-ratio power steering. Wheels: chrome-plated steel with P215/65R15 Goodyear Eagle GT blackwalls on the GN; the WE4 Turbo T substituted aluminum wheels and bumper supports to save weight; the GNX wore 16-inch mesh alloys under its flares. Brakes are the G-body disc/drum arrangement; verify the booster and master cylinder against the build before ordering — vacuum discipline on a boosted car matters, and the check valve in the booster line is a small part with a big job.

Chapter 8 — Paint, Trim, and the Black-Only Rule

Every 1987 Grand National is black: lacquer code 19U (WA848) on the SPID label, with blacked-out bumpers, moldings, grille, and trim — 'black; bumpers, moldings, grille, and exterior trim' in the factory's own equipment list. Interior is the gray two-tone treatment (trim code 583 in the late-run required package) with black carpet. The restoration trap is the paint system itself: the factory finish was lacquer, long unavailable in original form, so every repaint is a documented modern equivalent — matched to the WA848 chip, and recorded in the car's file.

Chapter 9 — Production Numbers and Rarity

1987 turbo Regal	Built	Factory rating
Grand National (WE2)	20,193	245 hp / 355 lb-ft
GNX	547	276 hp / 360 lb-ft
Turbo T (WE4)	1,547	245 hp / 355 lb-ft
Regal Limited turbo	1,035	245 hp / 355 lb-ft
Base Regal turbo	4,268	245 hp / 355 lb-ft

Figures follow the Turbo Regal Facts and Figures Book as published by the marque registry (gnttype.org). Totals in secondary sources vary (some report 26,555 total turbo cars against the table's 27,590) — the per-model counts above are the consistent ones, and this guide prints them with the variance named rather than averaged away.

Chapter 10 — Rust-Prone Areas and Inspection Guide

G-body rust, G-body places: rear frame rails at the axle kick-up, floor pans, door bottoms and lower skins, rear quarter panels, the trunk floor, and the body mounts. Hatch-roof (CC1 T-top) cars add the roof channels and pillar bases — lift the seals and look. Turbo cars add a question under the hood: heat-cycled turbo plumbing hides corrosion behind its shields. Magnet, light, photographs, notes — before negotiation (Chapter 14).

Chapter 11 — Restoration Sequence for the 1987 Grand National

- **1. Document** — dash VIN, SPID label (photograph it first), engine and transmission identification, photographs as found.
- **2. Name the car honestly** — WE2 Grand National, GNX, WE4, or turbo Regal. The SPID decides, and the budget follows.
- **3. Preserve the label** — the trunk-lid SPID is never painted over, peeled, or 'duplicated.' Mask it; work around it.
- **4. Disassemble by system**; intercooler, ducting, and turbo hardware are tagged and stored as matched sets.



- **5. Frame and metal**, then drivetrain to its documented calibration, paint to 19U/WA848 in a documented modern equivalent, trim to the SPID codes.
- **6. Verify against the SPID** at every step.

Chapter 12 — Engine Specifications at a Glance

Item	Grand National (LC2)	GNX
Rating	245 hp @ 4,400	276 hp @ 4,400
Torque	355 lb-ft @ 2,000	360 lb-ft @ 3,000
Induction	Intercooled Garrett turbo, SFI	Ceramic-impeller Garrett, larger intercooler
Compression	8.0:1	8.0:1
Build	20,193 (WE2)	547, ASC/McLaren

Chapter 13 — Options and Factory Details

- CC1 hatch roof (T-tops); CF5 astrorooftop (glass sunroof).
- C49 electric rear-window defogger; AU3 power door locks; A90 remote trunk release; A31 power windows.
- WG1 six-way power driver seat; AT6 manual seat-back recliner.
- K34 electronic cruise control; U52 electronic instrumentation; UM6 Delco radio (late-run required).
- YA6 theft-deterrent system; T82 Twilight Sentinel lamp control.
- G80 limited-slip differential — required in the late-run package.

Chapter 14 — Buyer Inspection Checklist

- SPID label present, legible, and its VIN matches the dash plate; WE2 (GN) or the GNX paper trail found.
- VIN engine digit 7 (LC2) confirmed — a turbo Regal is not automatically a Grand National.
- Black paint 19U/WA848 on the SPID; gray interior consistent with trim codes.
- Intercooler and factory ducting present; turbo hardware identified and dated against the build.
- GNX claims: serialized plaque, ASC hardware, conversion paperwork — nothing else carries the premium.
- CC1 cars: roof channels and pillars inspected with seals lifted.
- Rust map (Ch. 10) with photos, rear rails included.
- Late-run cars (after early August 1987): the 17 required options checked against the SPID.

Chapter 15 — Casting Numbers, Codes, and Date Codes

Identity on these cars is code-driven: the LC2 engine code in the VIN and on the SPID, the WE2 package code, paint 19U/WA848, trim 583 on late-run cars, and the build sequence embedded in the serial. Component date discipline follows the flagship rule: castings and tags should precede the car's build and sit close to it, and the intercooler-era hardware (1986–87 only) must be present in the correct generation of parts — 1984–85 'hot-air' components on an '87 are a story that needs documents.



Chapter 16 — Clones and Conversions: Tells That Matter

No modern-era car is cloned harder than this one: T-Types and base turbo Regals wear GN badges within a weekend. The tells are administrative, and that's the good news — the SPID's WE2, the VIN's LC2 digit, and the build paper form a triangle a clone rarely closes. Paint and badges prove nothing; codes and documents prove everything. A honestly described turbo Regal is a fine car. An undocumented 'GN' is a Regal with a story, and it should be bought and sold as one.

Chapter 17 — Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources

No torque value is printed here that cannot be traced to the factory service literature. The discipline is printed instead: threads chased and clean, lubrication as the manual specifies for the value in use, the printed pattern in at least three steps, and re-checks after the first heat cycle where the manual calls for them. Turbo-system fasteners and clamps get the same respect as head bolts — boost finds loose hardware at the worst moment. Take values from the 1987 Buick service manual in Sources, and record what you used.

A Note on Documentation

Turbo Regal identity lives on two stickers and a dash plate, and all three can be separated from the car by one careless afternoon: a trunk lid swapped in a body shop, a SPID label painted over, a dash plate 'cleaned up.' Photograph all three before anything else, transcribe the full RPO list into the car's file, and guard the originals through every stage of the work. Replacement labels exist in the hobby; a documented car with its original SPID is worth more than the same car with a fresh one, and the difference is exactly why the identity chapter comes third in this guide instead of last.

The same discipline covers modifications. These cars were tuned relentlessly when new — chips, boost, injectors — and a period performance part installed honestly is history, while the same part installed silently is a question mark in someone else's restoration. Write down what you change and keep the parts you remove. The next owner is owed the same honesty you were.

Recommended for this restoration

Shop exact-fit supplies on Amazon

- 1987 Buick Regal factory service manual
- Buick 3.8 turbo V6 engine rebuild kit
- Buick Grand National restoration parts
- 1987 Buick Regal parts catalog

As an Amazon Associate, RestorationEssentials earns from qualifying purchases made through these links.

Sources Consulted

Every specification in this guide was checked against published references before printing. Where sources disagree, this guide says so in the text rather than picking a number silently. The references below are the backbone of the technical chapters:



- **Buick factory literature.** the 1987 Buick Regal service literature and dealer ordering information — authority for torque values, specifications, and RPO definitions
- **Turbo Regal Facts and Figures Book data.** production counts and ratings as published by the Turbo Regal registry (gnttype.org)
- **Hagerty valuation research.** Grand National and GNX model history, performance figures, and production context
- **Old Cars Weekly feature reporting.** the August 1987 production-extension decision and the late-run required-options package
- **RPO and SPID documentation.** option-code definitions (WE2, LC2, CC1, G80, 19U/WA848) as documented in marque technical references

A note on numbers. Factory literature, period road tests, and marque historians do not always agree — production totals, horsepower ratings, and paint codes all have documented conflicts. This guide uses the best-supported figure in each case and flags the conflict where one exists, so you can judge for yourself.



Thank You

Thank you for choosing this RestorationEssentials guide. Whether this is your first 1987 Buick Grand National or your fiftieth, you picked one of the great ones, and the fact that you are doing your homework before you turn a wrench puts you ahead of most of the field.

These cars survived because people like you refused to let them disappear. Every correct fastener, every properly decoded tag, every hour spent getting the details right keeps the history honest for the next owner and the next generation of enthusiasts.

The last of the black cars — a V6 that humbled V8s and a division that went out swinging. Keep its paper straight and it will always be what it claims to be.

If this guide helped your build, we would love to hear about it. Good luck with the restoration, and enjoy every mile.

— The RestorationEssentials Team